

THE GOVERNMENT HASN'T LEARNT ANY LESSONS AS IN THE 1993 BLASTS TOO, RDX WAS BROUGHT IN ON BOATS FROM PAKISTAN

Is Anyone LISTENING?

Centre repeatedly rejected requests for coastal security

■ On April 4, 2003, the Gujarat Government sends a Rs 371-crore five-year plan to the Centre to secure the 1,600 km-long coastline.

■ In 2004, the UPA comes to power and seeks a revised coastal security plan from the Gujarat Government. Accordingly on May 30, 2005, the Gujarat Government sends a revised plan of Rs 321 crore.

■ The UPA truncates the plan and approves a Rs 58-crore plan that envisages setting up of 10 police stations which Gujarat has already implemented.

■ Realising that Rs 58 crore is inadequate to guard the coastline, the Gujarat Government forwards another plan of Rs 219 crore for Centre's approval which is rejected.

■ On July 5, 2007, the Gujarat Government sends a letter to the Centre requesting it to reconsider its decision. It receives a reply stating that the plan hasn't been accepted and will be considered only in 2010.

■ In April 2008, L.K. Advani meets the PM and requests that Gujarat Government's plan be reconsidered.

■ On July 17, the Gujarat Government requests the Centre for reconsideration instead of waiting till 2010.

■ On November 21, the Centre again turns down the proposal saying that it will be reconsidered only in 2010.

responsibilities and inability to provide quick decisions and responses.

Since augmenting maritime security is a slow process, the induction of manpower and platforms take a few years—it is essential to predict the next likely terrorist targets, accessible by sea. "Though Mumbai will remain an obvious target and needs maximum security, other tourist resorts like Goa, Port Blair and Chennai popular with American, British and Israeli tourists, also need tighter security immediately," says Vice-Admiral Arun Kumar Singh, former DG Coast Guard.

Nothing worries the authorities in Gujarat as

much as the vulnerability of important industrial installations that dot the coastline from Kutch to Valsad. This strip boasts of some of India's biggest industrial establishments—the Reliance and Essar crude oil refineries on the Jamnagar coast, major ports like Kandla, Adani and Pipavav, the petrochemical installations of Reliance and others at Hazira near Surat and the new industries that have come up around Dahej port near Bharuch. Terrorists armed with explosives who sneaked into Mumbai can easily strike these installations, particularly the crude oil and petrochemicals complexes, senior state police officials say.

Hazira is India's petrochemical hub where 50 per cent of India's gas is currently processed and the starting point of GAIL's Hazira-Bijapur-Jagdishpur pipeline. Less than half the ammunition used by the terrorists in Mumbai could wipe out Hazira due to the inflammable nature of the industrial units in the area. Says Southern Gujarat Chamber of Commerce and Industry president, Chetan Shah, "Places like Hazira, Jamnagar and Dahej should be provided both aerial and naval cover because a terror attack on one of these industrial centres could paralyse India itself."

For long, there have been apprehensions that some of the fishermen caught by the Pakistani Maritime Security Agency while fishing in the sea waters around the Saurashtra-Kutch area may be falling prey to the machinations of the Pakistani spy network, though evidence is hard to come by. So far only one returnee fisherman has come under the scanner of Indian security agencies. However, as a top intelligence official in Kutch puts it, "Hundreds have been in Pakistani jails and at least some might have fallen into the trap. We just don't have the skills to detect it."

"We will go after them and make them pay a heavy price," or something to that effect is what the Prime Minister said in his address to the nation. His words would've sounded credible if the authorities had acted on time, always. But if his Government continues to dither and is found to be woefully slow in reacting—as happened in Gujarat—it won't be long before the terrorists strike again.

with Sandeep Unnithan